

ERIN PARISH

INTO THE BLUE AGAIN

The exhibition runs through January 10th at Jeffrey Coploff Fine Art LTD, 526 West 26th Street, 2nd Floor. Please stop by.

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JEFFREY COPLOFF FINE ART LTD.

526 WEST 26TH STREET 2ND FLOOR NEW YORK, NY 10001 TEL: 212-674-1024

Ὅδὸς ἄνω κάτω μία καὶ ὡυτή "The way up and the way down are the same." —Heraclitus

The paradox at the heart of Erin Parish's work has kept me engaged for well over a decade. The songs she sings are all of inner solitude, and this theme runs true throughout all her work, clear back to the work of her adolescence and even, touchingly, in the paintings she did as a child. When I met her, when she was seventeen or so, she was already startlingly accomplished at the counterpoint of interior states, which she executed not only with technical skill but a depth of feeling rare for so young an artist.

Inner solitude is the constant in her work: but, for Erin, it is the contradictions within that solitude which have always formed, and continue to form, its dialectic. Menace shivers into dream and reverie; abstraction and form converse with one another constantly, creating a dialogue which I have described elsewhere as "a hypnotic pull in two very different directions...the drunkard's loss of consciousness, the swimmer's last gasp of oxygen, the lights of the delivery room or the deathbed."

The paintings which comprise "Into the Blue Again" are deeply meditative, like all Erin's work, but the title of the show itself illustrates beautifully the harmonies inherent in her opposites. Where, exactly, are we going when we go "into the blue," in which direction? Both ways: in rising, we sail up to the heaven, and the blue of the æther (*Ciel*, *Grey Tender*); but we pass down into blue again when we sink through day into darkness, down to the bottom of the sea (*Fathom*). The immensities in either direction are eternal. And the mystery and the delight of both extremes—the blue of paradise, the blue of the ocean floor—exists not only in these solemn antipodes but in the center, right in front of us, where they meet each other: upon the sparkling surface of deep waters (*True*); in the calm equilibrium between background and foreground (*Dusk*) or the balance between earth and sky, the place where the worlds meet (*Fog*). But even here, at ground zero and beyond contradiction (or so it might seem) nowhere is the push and pull of opposites more evident—a yes/no/yes/no thrumming back and forth like a pulse even within her deepest silences.

In moving into the blue we also move beyond it, into regions which are at once expansive and contained, like the iridescent crenellations within an oyster shell. Within—under layer upon layer of pearly nacre—rests a secret. The simplicity of *True* and *Fathom* deepens into enigma in paintings such as *Grey Tender*, *Ciel*, and *Lullaby*—which acknowledge the blue end of the spectrum at each polarity yet transcend it, in an idiom which itself balances between nothing and not-nothing, wakefulness and sleep, abstraction and form, the absence of color but yet its presence too. And in her ambiguities is a realm of deep rest which nonetheless stirs, and questions itself, and moves as constantly as waves on the water or clouds across a windy sky.

Donna Tartt, New York City, 4 October 1997

"... AS EVERYONE KNOWS, MEDITATION AND WATER ARE WEDDED FOREVER." Herman Melville, *Moby Dick*

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